About the "Mishna LeChok" Learning

The great importance of learning the order of "**Chok LeYisrael**" is well known. It was arranged by the holy Arizal and his holy disciples, and ever since it has been learned in every generation by the faithful of Israel, as a fixed daily portion ("chok"), so that no day passes without learning in every part of the Torah. And not only by them: it has also been learned by the tzaddikim of the generations, the cedars of Lebanon and giants of Torah, since this order of learning is built on the way of Kabbalah and brings about great tikkunim in all the worlds, as is known to those versed in it.

However, many who learn "**Chok LeYisrael**" ask "who will show us good?", and feel that something is missing. Every day they invest in learning one chapter from the Six Orders of Mishna, and on some days this is not easy at all, since some chapters are long and some are hard to understand and need great effort; still, they learn a full chapter every single day. Yet after all this they do not merit to complete all Six Orders of Mishna each year, because the Mishna chapters spread through the learning of "Chok LeYisrael" (324 chapters in number) lack more than a third of the Mishna (201 of the 525 chapters in all of Mishna). And on Simchas Torah, when they dance and rejoice at completing the Written Torah, they do not merit to rejoice as well at completing the Oral Torah.

Indeed, more than a hundred years ago the author of "**Misgeres HaShulchan**" on Kitzur Shulchan Aruch already raised this, in siman 151, in "Lechem HaPanim" note 1. He begins by citing the sefarim that learning Mishnayos is beneficial for the neshamah, and refers to siman 27 se'if 3, where it says that it is good to learn "Chok LeYisrael" every day. He continues: "We counted the Six Orders of Mishna and saw that these Mishnayos are missing from Sefer Chok, etc.", lists all the missing tractates and chapters, and concludes: "They total two hundred chapters (perhaps he did not count chapter 6 of Avos, which is really a baraisa, as the commentators write). The proper advice for completing the Six Orders of Mishna every year: learn in the sefer "Chok LeYisrael" every day, etc., and learn the two hundred additional chapters at four chapters each week, that is, half a chapter of Mishnayos every night before sleep, and one chapter on Shabbos." End quote.

His advice is good in general, but in practice it can be difficult, since some chapters are long and take much time, and in this way all the chapters are learned in order, with no distinction between long and short. Therefore we built this calendar, dividing them evenly over every day, so that it does not burden the fixed learning and does not, chas veshalom, become a case of "whoever adds, subtracts", and so that it is spread over the entire year.

This is the order of learning in brief. **A:** On every weekday, which also has the Mishnayos chapter of Chok, five more mishnayos of the added chapters are learned. **B:** On Shabbos, which has no Mishnayos chapter of Chok, ten mishnayos of the added chapters are learned. **C:** In the weeks of joined parshiyos (some only in non-leap years), when completing the Mishnayos within the year requires learning each day the chapters of both parshiyos, there is no learning of the added Mishnayos. **D:** Since the order of the added Mishnayos has no particular significance, we used the opportunity to fulfill what Chazal said at the beginning of Pesachim, "**One asks and expounds the laws of the festival before the festival**", and arranged the tractates connected to the festivals to be learned before them (mainly in non-leap years): Shekalim in Parshas Mishpatim, Megillah in Parshas Tetzaveh, Avos in the parshiyos after Pesach, Taanis in Parshas Devarim, and from Parshas Shoftim the tractates Rosh Hashanah, Yoma and Sukkah.

After consulting with many who learn "Chok LeYisrael", many of them said that even this division, though easy and usefully arranged, still leaves many learners without the time needed to add this learning as well. They therefore asked, rightly, for an order that completes the Six Orders of Mishna every two years, so that they can add a little Mishnayos learning each day and still complete the Six Orders of Mishna at least once every two years. So we took care of this too, and arranged an order of only three mishnayos a day of the Mishnayos added to Chok, completing the Six Orders of Mishna once every two years.